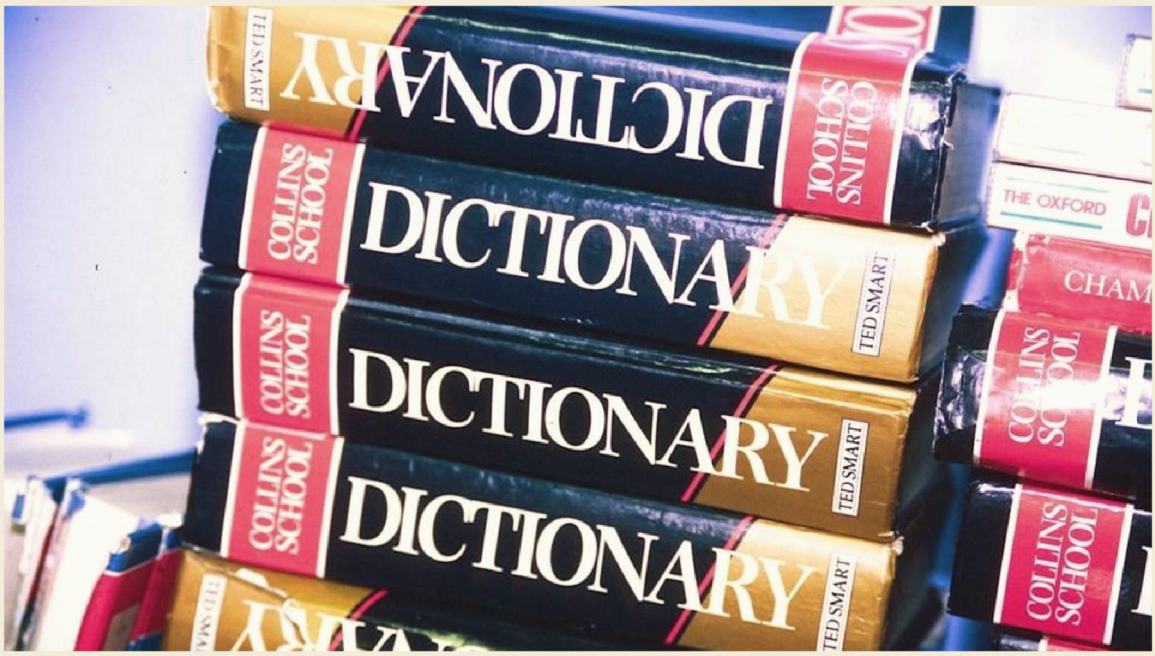
‘Maxxing’ selected as Dictionary.com word of the year

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A pile of dictionaries

Americans have gone all in on “maxxing”, making it the 2026 Word of the Year for Dictionary.com.

Short for maximising, the term “can be used on its own or added to the end of any word to convey you’re doing something to the fullest or optimizing it as much as possible”, Dictionary.com said in a statement.

It’s a major departure from two years ago, when the site, after analysing US social media trends, news stories, and search data, chose demure as word of the year. Last year’s was “67”.

“Maxxing is the linguistic manifestation of a culture increasingly preoccupied with getting the most out of everything,” said Steve Johnson, director of lexicography for the Dictionary Media Group.

Digital media used “maxxing” nearly 19 times more in August 2026 compared to the 2025 monthly average, Dictionary.com found. The site also considered affordability, data centre, odyssey, and the shortened form of uncle, “unc”, as potential words of the year.

On social media, many people in Generation Z and younger - those under 30 - post extensively about their maxxing efforts to achieve all sorts of perfection.

Influencers focused on fitness and wellness post about “proteinmaxxing” and “fibermaxxing”. Those giving their full attention to improving sleep habits say they are “sleepmaxxing”.

The influencer Clavicular has gained thousands of followers as he chronicles his extreme “looksmaxxing” - working to meet a set of prescribed criteria for attractiveness, with particular importance given to jawlines, eyes and physique.

“Whatever we’re doing, we want to push it further,” Johnson said. “But its expanding uses also reveal how people are responding to that impulse. Some embrace it. Some exaggerate it for laughs. Others subvert it entirely to describe stepping back from the relentless pursuit of more.”

People were playing with the term - and idea - for decades before Clavicular started posting videos.

In the opening song for the 1990s television show The Fresh Prince of Bel-Air, for example, Will Smith raps: “Chillin’ out, maxin’, relaxin’ all cool.”

“Unfortunately, by the time the dictionary gets a hold of it, that probably means that it’s reached critical mass,” says teacher Lauren Cella.

Cella, a content creator known for her viral Gen Z history lessons, says she and her students have been using “maxxing” for some time as a suffix.

“They’re actually, in their own way, reinventing grammar, which I think is super cool,” she says.

Maxxing gives the students permission to “optimise to meet a goal” or do something others might think of as “cringe”, and allows them to own it, she says.

“It’s a fun, harmless way that kids are expressing themselves and sharing different goals that they have,” she says.

Linguist Vanessa Croft, who teaches English, says the internet and digital media make language move at “warp speed”, even faster than radio, film or television ever did. As swiftly as new terms are added to the lexicon, they can just as quickly fall out of favour.

“By the time millennials and Gen X or Gen Y start using the terms, Gen Z and Gen Alpha aren’t using those terms anymore,” she says.

While she and her secondary-school aged students are still “maxxing” too, they are now using it “almost ironically”, she says.

生词标注（新闻高频 + 词汇第二义项）

词	词性	中文	备注
go all in on	phr.	全力投入、孤注一掷	“Americans have gone all in on ‘maxxing’” 美国人在“maxxing”上全力投入；源自扑克，新闻中表示不遗余力地押注某事
short for	phr.	是……的缩略形式	“Short for maximising”（它）是 maximising 的缩写；句首省略主语的后置说明，新闻常见的压缩句法
convey	v.	传达、表达（意思）	“to convey you’re doing something to the fullest” 传达“你在把某事做到极致”；第二义项，第一义“运输”多用于具体货物
departure	n.	背离、转向	“a major departure from two years ago” 与两年前大相径庭；此处不是“离开 / 出发”，而是“偏离既有做法”
manifestation	n.	体现、表征	“the linguistic manifestation of a culture” 一种文化的语言表征；manifest 显现，学术与评论高频
preoccupied with	adj.	一心想着、执着于	“a culture increasingly preoccupied with getting the most out of everything” 越来越执着于把一切榨到极致的社会
lexicography	n.	词典编纂（学）	“director of lexicography” 词典编

词	词性	中文	备注
			纂主管；lexicon 词汇库、lexicographer 词典编纂者
chronicle	v.	记录、逐日记述	“as he chronicles his extreme ‘looksmaxxing’” 他记录自己极端的“颜值最大化”；名词“编年史”，动词用法为新闻常见
prescribed	adj.	规定的、预设的	“a set of prescribed criteria for attractiveness” 一套被规定好的吸引力标准；第二义项，非“医生开的（药）”
impulse	n.	冲动、内在驱力	“how people are responding to that impulse” 人们如何回应那股冲动；心理与商业报道常用
subvert	v.	颠覆、反用	“Others subvert it entirely” 另一些人则彻底反用它；sub-（在下）+ vert（转），从底下翻转原有含义
relentless	adj.	不停歇的、不留情的	“stepping back from the relentless pursuit of more” 从对“更多”的无休止追逐中退出
critical mass	n.	临界规模、普及临界点	“it’s reached critical mass” 它已经达到人尽皆知、自行扩散的程度；物理术语转义
cringe	n./adj.	令人尴尬（的事物）	“something others might think of as ‘cringe’” 别人可能觉得“尬”的事；网络语，此处作名词而非动词

词	词性	中文	备注
warp speed	n.	极速	“make language move at ‘warp speed’” 让语言以“曲速”变化；出自《星际迷航》，喻快得超乎寻常
lexicon	n.	（某语言或领域的）词汇总汇	“as new terms are added to the lexicon” 新词进入词汇库；指整体词汇系统，不是某一本词典
fall out of favour	phr.	失宠、不再流行	“they can just as quickly fall out of favour” 也可能同样迅速地失宠；英式拼写 favour
ironically	adv.	反讽地、说反话地	“using it ‘almost ironically’” 几乎是带着反讽在用；区别于句首“具有讽刺意味的是”